

Walkman for the common man

Sony Ericsson just announced, another phone up for release soon is the basic Walkman phone W205. Probably realizing that everyone is feeling the grunt of the economic recession including mobile phone user, they made the W205 more accessible to the users.

Mobile Phone Test

slight issues with clarity in zone 2. The earpiece volume itself is quite good. The handsfree is good enough for casual music listening and to make calls but music lovers obsessed with quality will find nothing of interest here. The lack of expansion beyond the 4 GB of inbuilt



HTC Touch Diamond

memory may also turn some people off.

There's nothing special about this handset to make it stand out. At a price tag of Rs. 18,990 users would surely expect more and we would expect a QWERTY keypad to make usability better.

Motorola Motoring A1600

Another Linux-based Motorola phone, the A1600 has a rounded profile and comes with a transparent flip which allows one to peek at the screen it protects. The A1600 is touch-based and has a really well built exterior. The call buttons are small but well laid out with good tactile feedback and the joypad is also easy to use. The volume buttons are on the side and comfortable to use with good tactility intuitiveness. The menu structure is easy to understand and simple. The A1600 has a large display (2.4-inches) that is quite crisp, although the fonts used could be better. The lack of a hardware keypad is also felt, although not as badly as on the ROKR E6 because this phone is wider, giving the onscreen keyboard a larger area as well. One of the most noticeable features is the addition of a talking dictionary that can translate any word into another language and pronounce the word as it would sound – very useful if you are travelling abroad. We tried it for some common words and the results were pretty good.

Other than that the 3.2-megapixel camera is useful and features autofocus and a slightly weak flash unit. Its antenna is strictly OK and call quality could have been better. The A1600 is a decent music player with good handsfree quality and decent volume on the loudspeaker. If Motorola had thrown in a QWERTY package, this would be a feature-loaded device at a price of Rs. 15,847. As it stands, it's not a bad phone but has the odd quirk that keeps us from recommending it sans reservation.

LG KT610

This is one of the first phones from LG based on the Symbian platform. It's a very nondescript device that has a very rugged matte finish.

The phone itself is a bit clunky but otherwise build quality and the materials used in its construction seem really good. We would have preferred the use of some metal instead of the boring plastic though. The outer keypad is large and the keys, although close to each other, have no ergonomic

issues. The outer screen is a bit colour deficient, but serves the purpose of notifying you of missed calls, alarms, messages and such. Open it like a compass box and you'll see a much larger (although not large enough) display that immediately looks a lot crisper. Here you will also find a full-QWERTY

keypad. The entire design is reminiscent of the Nokia Communicator series, which it would seem, LG has tried to ape. The QWERTY keypad is well laid out and the call buttons found outside are also thoughtfully repeated inside – allowing one to take calls with the device open as well as closed. Having said that, note that it is slightly awkward to hold in case of the former. The five-way joypad on the outside is also cloned on the QWERTY and navigation is a snap either way. The inner screen could have been much larger if only the speaker grilles were a little more subtle but LG wanted a bit of garishness in this regard.

The inner keypad although having well spaced keys has other problems – key feedback is a little hard and this keypad is not comfortable when typing out long emails.

We see this as a glaring flaw since it's obvious that the QWERTY is one of its selling points. That being said the outer keypad makes up for the inner one's flaws and is excellent.

The inner display isn't as crisp as we'd like and the icons do not seem as lively as a result of this. Its two megapixel camera is not really useful. In call quality, the phone is a mixed bag with the phone doing well in zone 1 and letting itself down in zone 2 which is a region that really stresses the antenna since that zone is located right in the basement of our building. The handsfree unit offers good quality for music playback, although it's not good enough to recommend as a music phone. Overall, at a price tag of Rs. 15,990 the KT610 is a neat phone with quite a few features and the fact that it's based on the Symbian platform means that there are plenty of applications available for use. It's also one of the few phones with two screens and two usable keypads; however, it's

not quite a multimedia user's delight and business users will demand more – so it misses the recommendation boat.



LG KT610

Nokia N78

The successor to the vastly popular N73, the N78 is slimmer, built better and has a slightly better display. The black/silver model we received looks smart and its glossy finish goes a long way in attracting attention. The battery cover is plasticity and there is a problem with the retention on the top – it's not built well and will likely break with heavy usage and this is a glaring omission from Nokia who are known for solid handsets. The keypad is nothing more than four horizontal lines each with its set of non-segregated keys. Initially we had our reservations about such a layout – surely this would be a usability nightmare. Well not quite – in truth the keypad isn't good but it's a whole lot better than it looks. Button feedback is positive, although the keys are a bit hard. It does help if you use nails while typing, but how many of you, aside from the fairer sex, would bother growing those? Once you get the hang of typing, things do get better and we were able to type quite fast. The main menu button and the call buttons are built into



Motorola Motoring A1600

